

Cyber crime

The new age menace

Pradeep Narayan

In the current age of the IT revolution, more and more people are getting hooked into the cyber world for their various needs. There is a distinct reliance on computers and the internet now for email, entertainment, shopping (online shopping), airline and rail tickets, banking, trading and the list goes on. While it does make our lives simpler and convenient, it also poses dangers to us in an unprecedented way by exposing their identity in the public domain. Details of our personal information, such as name, addresses, passwords and bank accounts are in the process of being attacked by various fraudsters, hackers, terrorists and criminals freely roaming the cyber world.

It makes perfect sense for users to understand the online security threat they are exposed to while surfing the web. Just what are those risks and threats that we are talking about? Among dangers are hostile viruses, hackers accessing your system and stealing vital information like credit card details and committing fraud, unsecured wireless networks, spyware on your system, and identity theft.

As a user, how can you enhance your online security?

In the following section, we will discuss the kind of risks that you are exposed to and the ways in which you can tackle those risks. There is no fool-proof system, but it doesn't hurt to be a little careful while on the internet.

Guidelines

How to protect personal and work data

■ Protect yourself with relevant software from viruses and trojan horses that may steal or modify data on your own computer. A trojan horse program is software that claims to do something genuine, but does exactly the opposite. For example, a program that claims it will speed up your computer may actually be sending personal PC information to a hacker.

■ Update your PC with the latest anti-virus software and operating system patches. Make sure these updates happen automatically.

■ Install a personal firewall and anti-spy ware to protect your PC.

■ Periodically change your online passwords.

■ Check your credit card and bank statements regularly and report any irregularities to the relevant authorities.

■ Modify Internet Explorer or other browser security settings to limit the amount of information you are willing to accept from a web site. Microsoft recommends to set the security settings for the internet zone to medium or higher.

The need to update your browser

When you use the internet, you view web sites in a *browser*. A browser is a program that accesses and displays files and other data available on the internet and other networks. Browser programs are frequently updated to add functionality and address problems. If you are using an older version, there could be security issues (someone could hack into your computer).

How to do it?

Download the latest or updated browser you are using from the company's web site over the internet. It might ask for information about your computer such as what operating system it uses — Vista or Windows XP. Then follow the instructions on your screen.

■ Save it to your computer, it will be saved as an executable file. Once the download is complete, go to the file where you saved it, and double — click on it. This will automatically install the new browser on your computer.

Be careful while doing online shopping

■ Shop online only with known and reputable merchants; enter their URLs yourself, and do not click on links in emails; these may very well contain hidden commands to trick you

■ Do not respond to any emails asking for personal information

■ Check web sites' privacy policy before providing any personal or financial information

